

What To Do When Intimate Images Are Leaked Online

A Step-by-Step SOP for Women in India

Last verified: July 2026. This is general information, not legal advice. Steps marked LAWYER involve a legal professional; everything else you can start yourself, right now, for free.

This is not your fault. Indian law treats this as a crime against you, and there are real, working mechanisms — government and platform-run — to get content taken down and to pursue the person responsible.

YOU do this yourself, no help needed **LAWYER** needs a legal professional **POLICE** law enforcement action **FREE SUPPORT** free government support service

Start Here: 3 Things To Do Right Now

Before anything else — do just these three things. Nothing more is required today.

- **If you're afraid of physical harm** (an ex-partner, stalker, or someone who knows where you live), call police on **112** first.
- **Don't respond** to threats, blackmail demands, or messages from whoever leaked the content. Don't engage, and don't pay — paying doesn't make it stop, it usually invites more demands.
- **Tell one person you trust.** Isolation is what abusers count on. You don't have to carry this alone, and you don't have to make every decision today.

Everything below is a checklist. Steps 2–6 can be done in parallel, in any order, entirely by you and for free — no lawyer needed to begin.

For directories of free legal aid, mental health support, and One Stop Centres near you, see sakhi181.org.

The Full Step-by-Step SOP

Step 0: Immediate safety and self-care **YOU**

Covered above — see "Start Here." Come back to this list once you feel steady enough to act.

Step 1: Preserve evidence before you report or request takedowns **YOU**

Once you report content, platforms may take it down — good news, but you'll lose the ability to screenshot it later. Before reporting anything:

- Take full-screen screenshots (including the URL bar, the username/account that posted it, timestamps, and view/like counts) of every place you find the content.

- Save the direct URL/link of each post, profile, or webpage.
- If it was sent to you directly (WhatsApp, email, DM), keep the original message itself, not just a screenshot — headers and metadata can matter later.
- Note the date you discovered each instance. Keep a simple log: date, platform, URL, action taken.
- Back this evidence up somewhere other than your phone (a private cloud folder, an email to yourself), in case your phone is lost or someone tries to delete the evidence.

Step 2: Use StopNCII.org to stop further spread YOU

StopNCII.org is a free, privacy-preserving tool you can use whether the images have already leaked or you're worried they might. It creates a unique digital fingerprint ("hash") of the image on your own device — the image itself never leaves your device or gets uploaded anywhere. The hash is shared with participating platforms (Meta/Facebook/Instagram, TikTok, Google/YouTube, Reddit, Bumble, OnlyFans, X, and others), which then block or remove matching uploads automatically, including future re-uploads.

- Eligibility: you must have been 18 or older when the image was taken, be identifiable in it, and currently have a copy of it (even a saved copy you don't want to look at again).
- It also accepts deepfake/AI-morphed nude images of you.
- It is not a legal process and doesn't involve police — a prevention/removal tool only. Do this alongside, not instead of, the other steps.

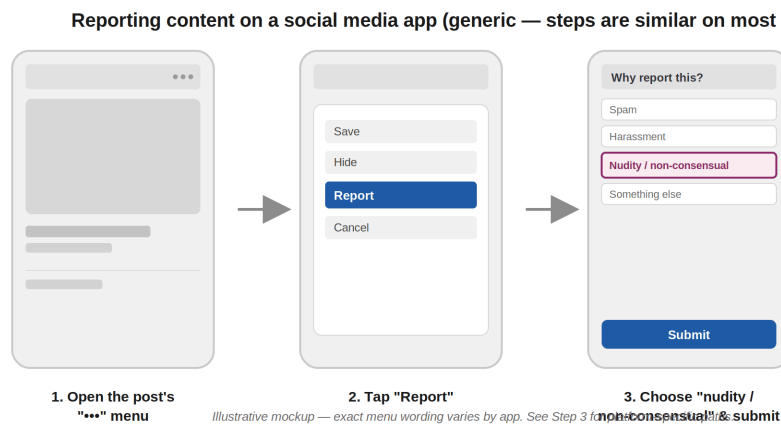
Step 3: Report directly to the platform(s) hosting the content YOU

Every major platform has a dedicated non-consensual intimate imagery (NCII) reporting flow, usually faster than a general "report post" button:

- Instagram/Facebook: report the specific post/story/profile, choosing "nudity or sexual activity" → "share without my permission."
- X (Twitter): use the "non-consensual nudity" report category.
- Telegram/WhatsApp groups: report the chat/channel in-app; for Telegram you can also email abuse@telegram.org.
- Adult or unknown websites: look for a "DMCA," "report abuse," or "content removal" link, usually in the footer.
- You can also route a report to the platform through the government's own portal, which forwards it directly to the intermediary: cybercrime.gov.in's "Report Abuse to Social Media Intermediary" page.

Under India's IT Rules, 2021 (Rule 3(2)(b)), platforms are legally required to remove or disable access to reported intimate/nude/morphed content within ****24 hours**** of the complaint. This is confirmed in the Ministry of Electronics and IT's October 2025 SOP on NCII, issued on the Madras High Court's direction.

- If a platform misses the 24-hour window or you're unhappy with its response, you can appeal to the Grievance Appellate Committee (GAC) at gac.gov.in — a government body set up specifically to review platforms' grievance decisions and failures to act.



General shape of the in-app reporting flow. Exact wording and menu placement differ by platform — use the platform-specific paths listed above.

Step 4: Get it removed from Google Search results **YOU**

Even if the original post is taken down or the host site won't cooperate, you can stop it from showing up in Google Search:

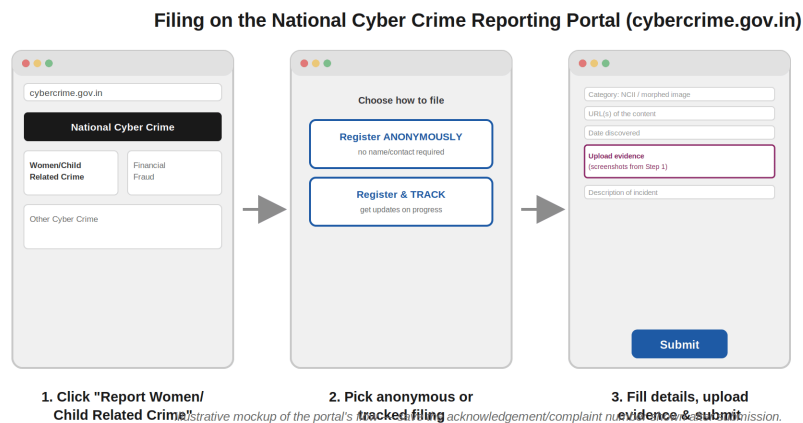
- Use Google's "Remove personal sexual images" tool (support.google.com/websearch/answer/16854698), or click the three dots on the image in Google Image Search → "Remove result" → "It shows a sexual image of me." This also covers AI-generated/deepfake nude images of you.
- You can submit multiple images in one request, and opt in to have Google proactively filter similar future results.
- Track all your requests through Google's "Results about you" hub (myactivity.google.com/results-about-you).
- Remember: this removes it from Google's search results, not from the website itself — you still need Steps 3, 5, and 6 to get it taken down at the source.

Step 5: File a complaint with the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal **YOU**

This is the central government channel and the fastest formal route to forcing takedowns and starting an investigation.

- Portal: cybercrime.gov.in — free, available 24/7, in multiple Indian languages.
- Click "Report Women/Child Related Crime." This lets you file anonymously if you choose, though sharing your details makes investigation and follow-up easier.
- Upload the evidence from Step 1 (screenshots, URLs, dates).

- You'll receive a complaint/acknowledgement number — save it.
- You can also call the Cyber Crime Helpline, **1930**, for immediate help, including faster freezing of any money involved in extortion.
- This portal is what triggers official takedown notices to platforms under Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, which carries more legal weight than an ordinary user report.
- If the case involves a fraudulent call, SMS, or WhatsApp impersonation (for example, a sextortion threat from an unknown number), also report it on the **Chakshu portal** (via sancharsaathi.gov.in), run by the Department of Telecommunications, which can block the phone number/IMEI involved.



General shape of the cybercrime.gov.in filing flow. The live portal's exact screens may vary — this shows the sequence of decisions and information you'll need.

Step 6: File a First Information Report (FIR) at a police station or cyber cell POLICE

You don't need to wait for Step 5 to finish — many people file the online complaint first and let it route to police, or go in person if they want a formal criminal case opened right away.

- Cybercrime has no jurisdictional limits in India — you can file at any police station or cyber cell, not just where you live or where the perpetrator is.
- Many cities have dedicated Cyber Crime Police Stations or Women's Cyber Cells; your state police website or the 1930 helpline can direct you to the nearest one.
- Bring your evidence log, ID, and your cybercrime.gov.in complaint number if you have one.
- Police are legally required to register your FIR. If a station refuses, you can escalate to the Superintendent of Police, the State Women's Commission, or the NCW (Step 9).

Step 7: Go to a One Stop Centre (Sakhi Centre) for combined support FREE SUPPORT

One Stop Centres (OSCs), run by the Ministry of Women and Child Development and locatable via the Mission Shakti portal (missionshakti.wcd.gov.in), are a single-window government support point specifically named in the MeitY SOP for NCII cases. In one visit, an OSC can:

- Help you file and track your complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.
- Arrange free legal and psychological counselling.
- Help you file a complaint with the local police, if you want that.
- Connect you with a free lawyer through the District Legal Services Authority (DLSA) or an empanelled advocate.

An OSC is a good option if you'd rather have one place walk you through everything above, instead of doing each step alone.

- Find your nearest OSC, DLSA lawyer, or counsellor listed on **sakhi181.org**.

Step 8: Send a legal takedown notice and, if needed, appeal non-compliance **LAWYER**

If a platform ignores your report or the 24-hour window, a lawyer can send a formal legal notice under Section 79 of the IT Act to the platform's designated Grievance Officer in India. This puts the platform on the record and starts the compliance clock again, with clear legal consequences (loss of "safe harbour" protection) if it's ignored.

- A lawyer can also file the GAC appeal (Step 3) on your behalf and follow up on it.
- This step is optional if the platform already complied through Steps 2–4 — it's for cases of delay, refusal, or repeat re-uploads.

Step 9: Approach the National Commission for Women (NCW) if you face delays **FREE SUPPORT**

If police are dismissive, slow, or you'd like an independent body pushing your case along:

- NCW 24/7 Helpline: **14490** (also listed as 7827-170-170).
- Online complaint: ncwapps.nic.in.
- Email: [complaintcell-ncw\[at\]nic\[dot\]in](mailto:complaintcell-ncw[at]nic[dot]in).
- NCW can take up your case directly with police, monitor investigation progress, and in serious cases set up an inquiry committee. Most states also have their own State Commission for Women, which can move faster on local matters.
- Your State Commission for Women's contact details are also listed on **sakhi181.org**.

Step 10: Get free legal help for prosecution or civil remedies **LAWYER**

You don't need to hire a lawyer to do any of the steps above, but one can help you preserve evidence correctly for prosecution, push back on a slow police response, or pursue civil remedies such as a court order for removal or damages.

- NALSA (National Legal Services Authority) gives free legal aid to all women regardless of income: helpline **15100** or **15750**, nalsa.gov.in.

- Every district has a District Legal Services Authority (DLSA), searchable via the NALSA site, which can assign you a lawyer at no cost.
- One Stop Centres (Step 7) can also connect you to a DLSA lawyer directly.
- A curated list of free and low-cost lawyers who take on NCII cases is maintained at sakhi181.org.

Step 11: Consider a civil suit or "John Doe" injunction for wide, viral spread LAWYER

If the content is spreading fast across many unknown accounts or domains and criminal takedowns aren't keeping up, a lawyer can approach the High Court for a "John Doe" (Ashok Kumar) injunction — an order against unknown/unidentified persons that directs ISPs and platforms to block the content wherever it appears, rather than site by site. This is also the route for pursuing damages through a civil defamation or privacy suit alongside any criminal case.

Step 12: Look after your mental health alongside the legal process FREE SUPPORT

Dealing with this is genuinely heavy, and the legal process can be slow even when it works. It's worth pairing the practical steps above with support for yourself, at any point — you don't have to wait until the rest is resolved.

- iCall (TISS) psychosocial helpline: **9152987821** (Monday–Saturday).
- Vandrevalla Foundation mental health helpline: **1860-2662-345** or **9999 666 555** (24/7).
- One Stop Centres (Step 7) also offer free short-term counselling alongside legal help.
- Tele MANAS (Government of India) 24/7 mental health helpline: **14416** or **1-800-891-4416**.
- A directory of counsellors experienced with NCII/image-based abuse cases is available at sakhi181.org.

Special Situations

- **If you're under 18, or the images involve someone under 18:** this is also a POCSO (Protection of Children from Sexual Offences) matter, not just NCII. Use the Childline helpline, **1098**; cybercrime.gov.in also has a dedicated POCSO e-Box reporting option.
- **If the images are AI-generated, deepfake, or "morphed":** the same laws and tools apply. StopNCII.org, Google's removal tool, and the IT Rules' 24-hour takedown obligation all explicitly cover synthetic/morphed intimate imagery, not just real photos.
- **If someone is blackmailing you (sextortion):** do not pay, and do not send more images or money to "prove" anything or make it stop. Screenshot everything, including any UPI IDs, phone numbers, or usernames used, and report to **1930** and cybercrime.gov.in immediately — these cases are often investigated as organised extortion rings, and police have had real success tracing and arresting these networks.

Legal Provisions You Can Cite

You don't need to know these to file a complaint, but recognising them can help in police or legal conversations:

- **Information Technology Act, 2000 — Section 66E:** punishes capturing, publishing, or transmitting images of a person's private parts without consent.
- **Section 67 / 67A, IT Act:** publishing or transmitting obscene / sexually explicit material electronically.
- **Section 72, IT Act:** breach of confidentiality/privacy by someone who had lawful access to the content (relevant if an ex-partner had original access).
- **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023** (replaced the IPC from July 2024) — **Section 77:** voyeurism (capturing or circulating images of a person in a private act without consent); **Section 78:** stalking, including online monitoring/harassment; **Section 79:** acts intended to insult a woman's modesty; **Section 356:** defamation.
- **IT Rules, 2021, Rule 3(2)(b):** legally obligates platforms to take down reported nude/intimate/morphed content within 24 hours of an individual's complaint.
- **IT Act, Section 79(3)(b):** basis for government takedown notices issued via the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, which carry more weight than an ordinary user report.

Sources

- Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Standard Operating Procedure to curtail dissemination of Non-Consensual Intimate Imagery (NCII), October 2025 (issued under Madras High Court directions, W.P. 25017/2025).
- Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, Rule 3(2)(b) and Rule 3(1)(d).
- Information Technology Act, 2000 — Sections 66E, 67, 67A, 72, 79(3)(b).
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 — Sections 77, 78, 79, 356.
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal — cybercrime.gov.in, including "Report Abuse to Social Media Intermediary."
- National Commission for Women — ncw.gov.in.
- National Legal Services Authority — nalsa.gov.in.
- StopNCII.org — How It Works / FAQ.
- Google Search Help — Remove personal sexual images from Search.
- JuriGram, "Deepfake Laws India 2026: Jail Term, How to Complain & Force Removal."

-----NO NEED TO ADD THIS-----

Quick Reference: Numbers and Links

Need	Contact
Police emergency	112
Cyber Crime Helpline	1930
National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal	cybercrime.gov.in
Report abuse directly to a platform	cybercrime.gov.in/Webform/report_abuse_social_media.aspx
Grievance Appellate Committee (platform appeals)	gac.gov.in
Chakshu portal (fraud calls / sextortion numbers)	sancharsaathi.gov.in
One Stop Centres / Sakhi Centres locator	missionshakti.wcd.gov.in
National Women Helpline	181
NCW Helpline	14490 / 7827-170-170
NCW online complaint	ncwapps.nic.in
Free legal aid (NALSA)	15100 / 15750, nalsa.gov.in
Childline (if a minor is involved)	1098
StopNCII.org (hash-block images)	stopncii.org

Need	Contact
Google image removal	support.google.com/websearch/answer/16854698
iCall mental health helpline	9152987821
Vandrevala Foundation mental health helpline	1860-2662-345 / 9999 666 555
Tele MANAS mental health helpline (Govt. of India)	14416 / 1-800-891-4416
Directory: free legal aid, counselling, OSCs near you	sakhi181.org

•